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It was a near-perfect end to the season for Neeraj Chopra. Competing in the Diamond League finals in Brussels, he fell just one centimetre short of Anderson Peters' tournament-winning throw of 87.87m. While Neeraj might not have won the title, he once again underlined his status as one of the most consistent athletes this season.

Over the course of 2024, he competed six times and placed in the top two on each occasion. In fact, the last time Neeraj finished outside the top two was back in 2021.

Between then and the Kuortane Games in Finland, the 26-year-old competed in 19 competitions, finishing either first or second — a feat that includes both a gold and silver medal at the Olympics and the World Championships.

No Indian athlete has a record like this, and it's unlikely many will in the future. Yet, a day after competing in Brussels, Neeraj downplayed his own achievement.

Instead, he spoke of the lessons learned throughout the year, revealing that he had been competing in Brussels with a fractured hand.

"As the 2024 season ends, I look back on everything I've learned throughout the year — about improvement, setbacks, mentality, and more. On Monday, I injured myself in practice, and X-rays showed that I had fractured the fourth metacarpal in my left hand. It was another painful challenge for me. But with the help of my team, I was able to participate in Brussels.

"This was the last competition of the year, and I wanted to end my season on the track. While I couldn't meet my own expectations, I feel this

was a season in which I learned a lot. I am now determined to return fully fit and ready. I want to thank all of you for your encouragement. 2024 has made me a better athlete and person. See you in 2025," Neeraj posted on his social media accounts.

This self-assessment didn't come out of the blue. Although he had won silver in Paris with a throw that would have earned him gold in five of the previous six Olympic Games, he still seemed disappointed with the result, incidentally the best performance by an Indian at the 2024 Games.

In the mixed zone, he spoke about competing since 2018 with an injured groin muscle. He had considered surgery to treat the recurring injury but kept postponing the procedure because he wanted to participate in major competitions like the Olympics and World Championships.

Despite his injury, he managed to keep his battered body in the mix and perform well. However, when he needed to produce the biggest throw of his career in Paris to challenge an inspired Arshad Nadeem of Pakistan, his body couldn't back him up.

It was a frustrating result, as Neeraj admitted. Besides the medals, what he really wants is to perform the way he knows he can. While he jokes about not being able to go past the 90m barrier, it is something that genuinely rankles him.

"I know there is a big throw in me, but I'm not able to get it out, because I'm not able to throw with the freedom I want. Every time I throw, I'm constantly thinking about not getting injured again," he said in the bowels of the Stade de France.

Neeraj had spoken then about potentially undergoing surgery for a long-term solution to his groin issue.

Curiously, though, he hasn't had the procedure yet. While the rest of the Indian contingent at the Paris Games returned to India, with several medal winners attending felicitations and other ceremonies, Neeraj stayed to compete.

He participated in the Diamond League in Zurich, followed by the Diamond League Finals in Brussels. He claimed he wanted to finish the season on the track, but it seems more likely that he was trying to end the season on his own terms.

If he was not satisfied with his performance in Paris, there's not much to be said about the other Indian performances in track and field this year.

Neeraj's silver medal was the only saving grace for the Indian track and field contingent in Paris. The rest of the Indian contingent struggled. The men's 4x400m relay team narrowly

Inside story: X-ray of Neeraj's hand showing his fracture in the metacarpal. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

